Nimzo-Indian Defense

ECO E20-E59 | 104 named lines | Nimzo / Queen's Indian / Catalan family

In one sentence: Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Memory pattern: Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O dxc4

Key ideas

1. Nimzo: pin Nc3 and fight for e4; trade the bishop for knight to damage structure.
2. Queen's Indian: Bb7 and ...Be7 control e4 without weaknesses.
3. Catalan: use the long diagonal and queenside pressure.
4. Bogo-Indian: solid, flexible and low-risk for Black.
5. Plans revolve around e4, the c-file, and whether White gets the bishop pair.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.19** (equal, depth 16). Best: Bxc4.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.
2. Where does my king go?	Kings castle short; Black often keeps a healthy pawn structure by giving up the bishop pair.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bb4/Bb7 and the long diagonal. White: Nc3, Bd3, Qc2, e4 break; Catalan: Bg2, Qc2, Nbd2.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O dxc4

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. c4	Space. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... Bb4	Pin Nc3. Develops the bishop to b4.
4. e3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
5. Bd3	Develops the bishop to d3.
5... d5	Central break. Occupies the center with a pawn.
6. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
6... c5	Counter in the center. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
7. O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
7... dxc4	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.



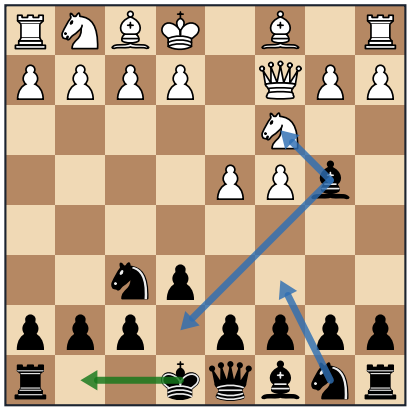
After 1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6



After e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Classical Variation E32 | 23 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2`

Stockfish: **+0.14** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: O-O.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Noa Variation, Berlin Variation, Zurich Variation, Keres Defense



Position after the line

Normal Variation E46 | 22 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O`

Stockfish: **+0.17** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: Bd3.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Gligoric System, Ragozin Variation, Bernstein Defense, Schlechter Defense



Position after the line

St. Petersburg Variation E43 | 16 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 b6`

Stockfish: **+0.33** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bd3.
What to look for: d4 (take the center); c4 (space); Nc3 (develop)
Sub-variations: with Ne4, American Variation, Romanishin-Psakhis Variation, Fischer Variation

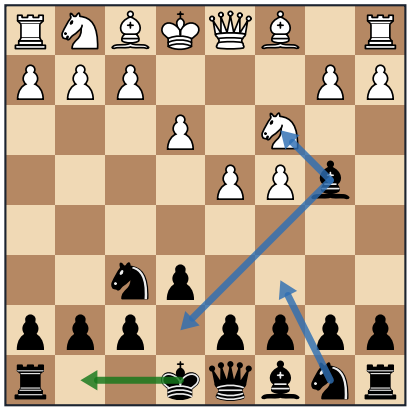


Position after the line

Sämisch Variation E24 | 11 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.a3`

Stockfish: **+0.15** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: Bxc3+.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Botvinnik Variation, Keres Variation, Romanovsky Variation, O'Kelly Variation

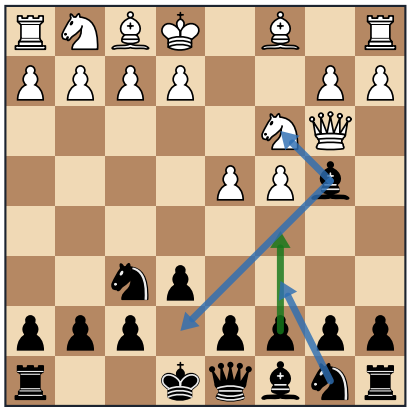


Position after the line

Rubinstein System E40 | 8 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3`

Stockfish: **+0.17** (equal, depth 21). Best next move: O-O.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Rubinstein Variation, Hübner Variation, Taimanov Variation



Position after the line

Spielmann Variation E22 | 5 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qb3`

Stockfish: **+0.00** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: c5.
What to look for: Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid); Bb4 (pin Nc3)
Sub-variations: Stahlberg Variation, Carlsbad Variation, Romanovsky Gambit

Detailed repertoire notes

Nimzo-Indian (E20-E59, Black)

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O Nc6 8.a3 Bxc3 9.bxc3 dxc4 10.Bxc4 Qc7 11.Bd3
e5 12.Qc2 Re8
```

Idea: Control e4 with the pin and play for ...c5/...d5 or ...b6 setups; give up the bishop pair for structure.

Structure: Hanging pawns or a doubled-c structure for White after Bxc3; Black has flexible pawn breaks.

Pieces: Bb4 pin, knights c6/f6, queen c7/e7, rooks e8/d8.

Plan: Keep the pin, take on c3 only if favorable, then play ...d5 or ...c5 with piece activity.

King: Castle after ...d5 or ...Bxc3; watch Bd3/Qc2 aiming at h7. **Opponent:** The bishop pair and a big center (e4, d4); Black hits e4 and keeps the c-file.

Watch out: Know the Rubinstein (4.e3) and Classical (4.Qc2) to avoid surprises.

Expert and coach view

Nimzowitsch (Nimzo-Indian), Karpov and Kramnik (Catalan) are strongly linked to these systems.

What a coach would tell you

Learn the key structure: doubled c-pawns versus bishop pair (Nimzo), the long diagonal fight (Catalan) and the e4 break. Play solid, flexible moves and avoid early commitments.

Why play it

Flexible, high-level systems: Black controls e4 with pieces; White fights with the bishop pair, the center or a fianchetto.

Typical mistakes

- Giving up the bishop pair without compensation (Nimzo).
- Playing ...d5 too early before the pieces are developed.
- Letting White play e4 with a big center unopposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxc3 followed by Ng5 or e4 winning the pinned knight if Black is careless.
- Qa4+ forks after ...b5 in Catalan lines.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Balanced endgames with small edges decided by structure and bishops.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Nimzo-Indian Defense (all lines)** E20
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4`
  - **Classical Variation** E32
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.Qc2`
    - **Berlin Variation** E38
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...c5`
      - **Pirc Variation** E39
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 c5 -> 5.dxc5 O-O`
      - **Steiner Variation** E38
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 c5 -> 5.dxc5 Bxc3`
      - **Macieja System** E39
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 c5 -> 5.dxc5 O-O 6.a3 Bxc5 7.Nf3 b6`
    - **Noa Variation** E34
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...d5`
      - **Botvinnik Variation** E36
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 d5 -> 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 Nc6`
      - **Main Line** E36
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 d5 -> 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 Ne4`
      - **San Remo Variation** E37
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 d5 -> 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 Ne4 7.Qc2 Nc6 8.e3 e5`
    - **Zurich Variation** E33
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...Nc6`
    - **Milner-Barry Variation** E33
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...Nc6 5.Nf3 d6`
    - **Keres Defense** E32
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...O-O 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 b6`
    - **Romanishin Gambit** E36
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...d5 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 c5`
    - **Vitolins-Adorjan Gambit** E32
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...O-O 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 b5`
    - **Belyavsky Gambit** E34
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...d5 5.cxd5 Qxd5 6.Nf3 Qf5 7.Qd1 e5`
    - **Modern Variation** E37
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qc2 -> 4...d5 5.a3 Bxc3 6.Qxc3 Ne4 7.Qc2 c5`
  - **Dilworth Gambit** E20
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e4`
  - **Kmoch Variation** E20
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.f3`
  - **Leningrad Variation** E30
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.Bg5`
    - **Averbakh Gambit** E30
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Bg5 -> 4...h6 5.Bh4 c5 6.d5 b5`
    - **Benoni Defense** E31
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Bg5 -> 4...h6 5.Bh4 c5 6.d5 d6`
  - **Mikenas Attack** E20
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.Qd3`
  - **Romanishin Variation** E20
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.g3`
    - **English Hybrid** E20
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Nf3 c5 5.g3 cxd4 6.Nxd4 O-O 7.Bg2 d5 8.cxd5 Nxd5`
  - **Rubinstein System** E40
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3`
    - **Taimanov Variation** E40
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 -> 4...Nc6`
    - **Rubinstein Variation** E42
      `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 -> 4...c5 5.Ne2`
      - **Main Line** E42
        `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 c5 5.Ne2 -> 5...cxd4 6.exd4 O-O 7.a3`

- **Sherbakov Attack** E42
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 c5 5.Ne2 -> 5...cxd4 6.exd4 O-O 7.c5
- **Hübner Variation** E41
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 -> 4...c5 5.Bd3 Nc6 6.Nf3 Bxc3 7.bxc3 d6
- **Spielmann Variation** E22
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.Qb3
  - **Romanovsky Gambit** E23
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qb3 -> 4...c5 5.dxc5 Nc6
  - **Carlsbad Variation** E23
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qb3 -> 4...c5 5.dxc5 Nc6 6.Nf3 Ne4 7.Bd2 Nxd2
  - **Stahlberg Variation** E23
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Qb3 -> 4...c5 5.dxc5 Nc6 6.Nf3 Ne4 7.Bd2 Nxc5
- **Sämisch Variation** E24
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.a3
  - **O'Kelly Variation** E26
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.a3 -> 4...Bxc3 5.bxc3 c5 6.e3 b6
  - **Keres Variation** E25
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.f3 d5 5.a3 Bxc3 6.bxc3 c5 7.cxd5 Nxd5 8.dxc5
  - **Botvinnik Variation** E24
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.f3 d5 5.a3 Bxc3 6.bxc3 c5 7.e3 O-O 8.cxd5 Nxd5
  - **Romanovsky Variation** E25
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.f3 d5 5.a3 Bxc3 6.bxc3 c5 7.cxd5 Nxd5 8.dxc5 f5
  - **Capablanca Variation** E29
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 c5 5.Bd3 Nc6 6.a3 Bxc3 7.bxc3 O-O 8.Ne2 b6 9.e4 Ne8
- **Three Knights Variation** E21
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.Nf3
  - **Korchnoi Variation** E21
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Nf3 -> 4...c5 5.d5
  - **Euwe Variation** E21
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.Nf3 -> 4...c5 5.d5 Ne4
  - **Shocron Gambit** E21
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Bb4 4.Nc3 c5 5.d5 b5
- **Normal Variation** E46
  1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 O-O
  - **Classical Defense** E48
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Bd3 d5
  - **Ragozin Variation** E51
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Nf3 d5
  - **Sämisch Deferred** E51
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Nf3 d5 6.a3
  - **Gligoric System** E53
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5
    - **Bernstein Defense** E56
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 -> 7.O-O Nc6
    - **Keres Variation** E53
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 -> 7.O-O b6
    - **Exchange Variation** E54
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 -> 7.O-O dxc4 8.Bxc4
    - **Bronstein Variation** E55
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 -> 7.O-O dxc4 8.Bxc4 Nbd7
    - **Smyslov Variation** E54
      1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 -> 7.O-O dxc4 8.Bxc4 Qe7
  - **Schlechter Defense** E52
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 b6
  - **Botvinnik System** E49
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Bd3 d5 6.a3 Bxc3 7.bxc3
  - **Bernstein Defense** E59
    1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O -> 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O Nc6 8.a3 Bxc3 9.bxc3 dxc4 10.Bxc4

- **Exchange Line** E58
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 c5 7.O-O Nc6 8.a3 Bxc3 9.bxc3`
- **St. Petersburg Variation** E43
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 b6`
  - **American Variation** E44
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 b6 -> 5.Ne2 Ne4`
  - **Fischer Variation** E45
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 b6 -> 5.Ne2 Ba6`
  - **Romanishin-Psakhis Variation** E44
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 b6 -> 5.Ne2 c5 6.a3 Ba5`
  - **with Ne4** E43
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 b6 -> 5.Bd3 Bb7 6.Nf3 Ne4`
- **Reshevsky Variation** E46
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 O-O 5.Ne2`
- **Simagin Variation** E46
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 O-O 5.Ne2 d5 6.a3 Bd6`
- **Ragozin Defense** E48
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 Nc6 7.O-O`
- **Ragozin Variation** E51
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 -> 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5 6.Nf3 Nc6 7.O-O dxc4`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

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1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4 4.e3 O-O 5.Bd3 d5
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Plan chain

White	d4 -> c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> g3
Black	Nf6 -> e6 -> Bb4 -> b6 -> Bb7

Three rules to remember

1. Control e4 with pieces, then break with ...d5 or ...c5.

2. White occupies the centre with e4 or plays a3/Bxc3 structures; Black strikes with ...d5/...c5 and piece pressure.

3. White wants the bishop pair and a big centre; Black wants to restrain e4 and hit the centre.

Pawn structure in one line

Black controls e4 with pieces (pin on c3 or Bb7) while White takes the c4/d4 centre or the bishop pair. Catalan: White uses g3/Bg2 pressure on d5 and the long diagonal.